Six months earlier, I'd come to Washington to put into practice ideas I'd believed in for decades. Now it was down to a few hours; Congress had two tax programs before it: the administration plan, and one crafted by the Democratic leadership meant to respond to the public clamor for tax relief. That plan proposed a fifteen-percent tax cut over two years, distributed most of the benefits to low-income people, and excluded many of the pump-priming features I felt were needed to encourage business investment and give a jolt to the economy. If the economic recovery plan was to work, I was convinced, Congress had to provide across-the-board relief equally for all Americans for three years. I believed this would create millions of jobs and trigger an economic resurgence.

I knew that, if we were going to get it passed, it wouldn't be enough to make Congress see the light; I had to make 'em feel the heat. That Monday I spent virtually every minute from early in the morning until seven thirty at night on the phone or in meetings with congressmen lobbying for the tax cuts; at eight, I made a televised broadcast to the nation in which I compared the Democrats' tax relief plan with ours and said: "The plain truth is, our choice is not between two plans to reduce taxes; it's between a tax cut or a tax increase." (Under their plan the total taxes paid by Americans would have gone up, not down.) Then I asked the people to make their views known to their elected representatives. The White House switchboard was swamped with calls from around the nation—more than after any speech I had given—and were six-to-one in favor of the administration's tax bill.

As soon as I got up the next day, I was on the phone again making calls to congressmen; most said their phones had been ringing off the wall since the speech with calls in support of the administration tax bill. "Tomorrow is the day," I wrote in my diary before going to bed the night of July 28,